

# CoARA Action Plan 2025-27

Università del Piemonte Orientale



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UNIVERSITÀ DEL PIEMONTE ORIENTALE

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**UPO** UNIVERSITÀ DEL PIEMONTE ORIENTALE

## Introduction

The Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) was established in December 2022 with the aim of translating into practice the Principles and Commitments set out in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA).

More than 700 international organisations, including more than 50 Italian universities, are involved in various capacities in research-related processes and activities (universities, research centres, authorities, funding bodies, evaluation agencies, scientific societies and other relevant actors). They joined the Coalition with the aim of reforming the methods and processes through which research, researchers and research organisations are evaluated.

The Università del Piemonte Orientale (UPO) joined CoARA in 2023 and, by signing ARRA, committed itself to pursuing, while respecting its autonomy, a common strategy aimed at a systemic reform of research assessment and to facilitating information exchange and mutual learning among all participants.

ARRA is based on 10 Commitments that aim to recognise, in assessment activities, results and practices that maximise the quality and impact of research:

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research;
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators;
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index;
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment;
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to;
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes;

7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use;
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition;
9. Communicate progresses made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments;
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

In this Action Plan (AP), ARRA Commitments are articulated in actions designed in accordance with the University's planning documents for the 2025-2027 time frame. In 2023, at the time of approval of ARRA, UPO already had some initiatives in place, which were consistent with the general principles of the Agreement; they then found full expression in these strategic documents.

## UPO Guiding Principles

Our current Strategic Plan (PS)<sup>1</sup> 2025-2030, approved by UPO Bodies in January 2025, envisages a number of objectives and related actions which are consistent with the aims of CoARA and the contents of ARRA.

As part of our research strategy, and linked to other key areas, we are rethinking assessment principles and methods. This reform is outlined in specific objectives within our Integrated Plan of Activities and Organization (PIAO)<sup>2</sup>, where these ideas are translated into practical actions. We have approached this with "integrated planning" in mind, meaning all our activities are designed to align seamlessly with the University's overall strategies and work in harmony with our other organizational and management tools.

The core idea behind the connection between PS and PIAO is **Public Value**. In the research world, this means developing innovative knowledge and expertise to meet the demands of a rapidly evolving global landscape. It also involves creating powerful collaborations with institutions, businesses, and the society at large to enhance the outreach of our discoveries, ultimately benefiting everyone.

In line with ARRA's research evaluation reforms that prioritize quality and impact, UPO strongly supports the freedom and independence of its research. We plan to use inter-/multi-/transdisciplinary scientific methods, developing partnerships with

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<sup>1</sup> **Strategic Plan**

<sup>2</sup> The **PIAO** (Integrated Activity and Organisation Plan) is the programming document that Italian public administrations use to plan and manage their activities, making the processes of acquisition and use of public resources more transparent.

external organizations and businesses. This strategy will also enhance different researchers' profiles and careers, promote research quality, and disseminate the principles of 'open science.'

## UPO Community Involvement

The actions that our PS lists are all about **co-creation**. This means we will involve everyone actively, from all the university personnel to our external stakeholders, in setting and achieving our goals.

Through regular "living labs" and "living camps," and with guidance from our rectors' delegates and the contacts we have appointed for CoARA and Open Science matters, UPO aims to work like a true "**team university**." Our goal is to gradually reduce inequalities and differences across the board.

Specifically for research and assessment, we want to foster a **collaborative and interdisciplinary work and training environment**. We envision something that's inclusive, sustainable (environmentally, economically, and socially), and built on trust and shared responsibility. We will share our strategic documents, goals, and action plans with the entire university community through a comprehensive communication effort. Plus, we'll provide regular updates on our progress, including organizational, process, and outcome changes as they happen.

## Action Plan UPO

The UPO Action Plan (UPO AP), which you can see outlined in the table below, is built around each CoARA Commitment. For each commitment, we have mapped out a series of actions that tie into the focus areas identified in our PS: Teaching, Research, Community Engagement (Third Mission and Social Impact), Internationalisation, and People & Resources.

Here's a quick rundown of UPO's actions:

- *Boost Essential Skills*. We will help people develop crucial transversal, inter-, multi-, and transdisciplinary skills – the kind you need to really grasp complex situations. We're also focusing on soft skills like communication, problem-solving, critical thinking, teamwork, distributed leadership, and creativity, all vital for effective professional interactions.

- *Drive High-Impact Interdisciplinary Research.* We are encouraging research that spans different disciplines, creating innovative partnerships and fostering projects that tackle complex issues from a holistic perspective.
- *Enhance Research Quality.* We will support our researchers in producing top-notch work by helping them publish in prestigious international journals, attend high-level conferences, and make the most of their findings.
- *Value Our Researchers.* We want to recognize our researchers, even through reward systems, to acknowledge their merit, encourage their professional growth, and create a stimulating, merit-based work environment.
- *Strengthen Connections.* We are aiming to build a stronger network, both nationally and internationally, with prominent universities, research institutions and centres. Our goal is to create a hub of excellence that sparks new ideas and promotes the free flow of knowledge.
- *Foster Social Impact.* We are promoting a culture of “Third Mission” (community engagement) and highlighting our University’s social responsibility and impact, both locally and globally, with a special focus on reducing inequalities and fostering inclusion.
- *Deepen Local Ties.* We will strengthen our existing relationships with key local players, including local institutions, foundations, banks, economic organizations, and cultural associations.
- *Share Our Discoveries.* We are committed to sharing research results and technology transfer initiatives, as well as the patentability of the knowledge we produce, through popular publications, patents, licenses, and other dissemination methods.
- *Go Global.* We want to integrate our University into a worldwide context by creating a study and research environment that is open to the world. This includes promoting outgoing mobility and developing collaborations with institutions across every continent.
- *Improve Faculty Careers.* We are enhancing merit-based recruitment and career progression mechanisms for our teaching staff. We will pay special attention to helping newly recruited researchers kickstart their university careers, offering them support and mentorship to create a welcoming environment for their entry into academia and the development of successful careers.
- *Invest in Our Staff.* We are valuing the “human capital” of our technical-administrative and library staff by investing in their training, skill development, and professional growth opportunities.

In the table below, you can see how UPO's actions (column 2) connect to the CoARA Commitments (column 1) and the objectives of both our PS (column 4) and PIAO

(column 5). The timeframe for UPO's actions (column 3) is 2025-2027, with annual monitoring to check for any deviations and make necessary adjustments. Specifically, we will have a major review and development of evaluation criteria, tools, and processes at the end of 2027.

Also included in the table are actions already in place since 2023, which align with ARRA and our current Action Plan:

- *Open Access Initiatives*. We have been active in Open Access<sup>3</sup> since 2008. In particular, our OA Group, established in 2010, has promoted open access themes, organized training sessions for PhD, UPO, and high school students, and championed the UPO "OpenThesis" project. Plus, our University's Open Access Policy was approved in 2021.
- *Valuing Third Mission Activities*. We started recognizing Third Mission activities in our "Guidelines for Formulating Proposals for the Use of Staff Points by Departments," approved by the Board of Trustees in May 2020.
- *"Enhancing Research" Program*<sup>4</sup>. This ongoing research training program for our UPO scientific community covers topics like European (Horizon Europe) and national funding opportunities, valorisation and impact opportunities, and UPO's indicators and tools for self-assessing research quality. The program also delves into data management and open science principles.

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<sup>3</sup> **Open Access Project**

<sup>4</sup> **Enhancing Research – Ongoing research training**

| CoARA Commitments                                                                                                                                                                   | UPO Actions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Timeframe                | Ref. PS              | Ref. PIAO  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------|------------|
| <b>C1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research</b>                                            | Introduce shared and transparent reward mechanisms that take performance in research into account, in the acquisition of funds from competitive calls and in the dissemination of knowledge                                                                                             | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.4             | VP2.RIC-4b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Design training initiatives for the development of soft skills in researchers related to the effective communication of research results                                                                                                                                                | Ongoing since 2023       | PS 4.1.3             | VP2.RIC-7b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Organise training/awareness-raising initiatives on the topics of Third Mission/Social Impact/Civic Outreach                                                                                                                                                                             | Ongoing                  | PS 4.3.1             | VP3.TM-1b  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Promote the dissemination of research results, of technology transfer initiatives and patentability of the knowledge produced                                                                                                                                                           | Ongoing                  | PS 4.3.5             | VP3.TM-5b  |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Design/implement an integrated merit assessment model in the access and career progression of academic staff                                                                                                                                                                            | Actions launched in 2020 | PS 4.5.1             | VP5.PER-1a |
| <b>C2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators</b>                   | Organise information/training initiatives on the assessment parameters used by national (ANVUR) and international (CoARA) Agencies for the assessment of research and development products of the UPO roadmap within CoARA                                                              | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.1<br>PS 4.2.2 | VP2.RIC-2b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Promote and enhance Open Science Open Data and FAIR principles also harmonising them with aspects related to research security                                                                                                                                                          | Actions launched in 2010 | PS 4.2.4             | VP2.RIC-2c |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Establish a Research Ethics Committee and a contact person for Research Integrity and Security                                                                                                                                                                                          | 2025                     | PS 4.2.2             | VP2.RIC-2d |
| <b>C3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index</b> | Implement and monitor, through specific indicators, the quality assessment of scientific research that also uses Research Infrastructures (IR) UPO. Indicators may consider the application of open science practices, FAIR data principles and the green open access publication mode. | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.8             | VP2.RIC-6d |
| <b>C4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment</b>                                                                                               | Although it monitors the main international rankings, our University does not consider them as criteria for the distribution of resources or for the provision of incentives. No actions based on these assessments have been planned so far                                            |                          |                      |            |
| <b>C5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to</b>                                                        | Introduce shared and transparent reward mechanisms that take performance in research into account, in the acquisition of funds from competitive calls and in the dissemination of knowledge                                                                                             | 2025-2027                | PS 4.5.4             | VP2.RIC-4b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Appoint contact persons for Open Science and CoARA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2025                     | PS 4.4.2             | -          |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Carry out the activities planned within the framework of the Commission for the valorisation of young researchers at the start of their careers                                                                                                                                         | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.4             | -          |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Organise information/training initiatives on the assessment parameters used by national (ANVUR) and international (CoARA) Agencies for the assessment of research and development products of the UPO roadmap within CoARA                                                              | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.2             | VP2.RIC-2b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                     | Promote and enhance Open Science Open Data and FAIR principles also harmonising them with aspects related to research security                                                                                                                                                          | Actions launched in 2010 | PS 4.2.2<br>PS 4.2.4 | VP2.RIC-2c |



| CoARA Commitments                                                                                                                                                                               | UPO Actions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Timeframe                | Ref. PS                          | Ref. PIAO                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>C6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes</b>                                                                                                                 | Organise training/awareness-raising initiatives on the topics of Third Mission/Social Impact/Civic Outreach                                                                                                                                    | Ongoing                  | PS 4.3.1                         | VP3.TM-1b                |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Design/implement an integrated merit assessment model in the access and career progression of academic staff                                                                                                                                   | 2025-2027                | PS 4.5.1                         | VP5.PER-1a               |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Define, communicate and apply a varied system of incentives - economic and otherwise - linked to measurable results                                                                                                                            | Actions launched in 2020 | PS 4.5.1                         | VP5.PER-1b               |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Participate in the National Chapter of CoARA and other working groups                                                                                                                                                                          | Actions launched in 2023 | PS 4.2.5<br>PS 4.4.1<br>PS 4.4.2 | -                        |
| <b>C7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use</b>                | Organise information/training initiatives on the assessment parameters used by national (ANVUR) and international (CoARA) Agencies for the assessment of research and development products of the UPO roadmap within CoARA                     | 2025-2027                | PS 4.2.1<br>PS 4.2.2             | VP2.RIC-2b               |
| <b>C8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition</b>                                                                                         | Strengthen the network of relationships, at national and international level, with prominent universities, institutions and research centres                                                                                                   | Ongoing                  | PS 4.2.5<br>PS 4.4.1<br>PS 4.4.2 | VP2.RIC-5a<br>VP2.RIC-5b |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Develop strategic partnerships, at national and international level, to create new networks and new ways of collaboration with other research institutions and to plan joint/double PhD programmes as well as doctorates of national interest. | Ongoing                  | PS 4.2.5<br>PS 4.4.1<br>PS 4.4.2 | VP2.RIC-5a<br>VP2.RIC-7a |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Improve internal communication; publish on the website principles/guidelines on the criteria and methods of internal assessment                                                                                                                | Ongoing                  | transversal to the SP            |                          |
| <b>C9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments</b>                                                                                       | Improve internal communication; publish the undertaken and realised actions on the University website                                                                                                                                          | Ongoing                  | transversal to the SP            |                          |
| <b>C10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research</b> | Carry out continuous internal monitoring of activities with a view to Quality Assurance (QA) PS 4 2.5                                                                                                                                          | 2025-2027                | transversal to the SP            |                          |



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